

India's esports potential

We sit down with Intel's gaming guys to learn about their plans for the Indian esports scene

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What is the breadth of Intel's investment into gaming?

Frank Soqui: We're getting close to our 14th Season with Intel Extreme Masters and we have a long and strong partnership with Intel. So we didn't just get into gaming over the last couple of years but we've been committed for a long time. I would submit that everything that we've done in compute have been always about these great experiences whether they're for the consumer, gaming, entertainment or for immersive experiences around consumer PCs. When it comes to gaming, this is the culmination of a lot of our investments from different perspectives. From the silicon perspective to marketing, sales, sponsorships with ESL, driving IEM, etc. We've just returned from Katowice about a month ago and we had about 232 million unique viewers turn up to watch the tournament online. So we're constantly looking for venues where we can start paying more attention to the audience and to the gamers in various regions. A couple of years ago we went to Australia, then we went to Chicago and it's probably been a long-time coming in terms of being here in India. It feels like what's happening in India in terms of infrastructure, player interest, the demographics, etc. has led to this. Everybody is very excited, from gamers to the audience. That's why we're here.

Could you elaborate on your partnership with ESL?

Lee Manchen: We believe that by getting our products in front of the esports audience is the best way to reach the



Frank Soqui, Vice President, General Manager Gaming Group, Intel and **Lee Manchen**, General Manager, Gaming & VR Sales, Intel

highest number of gamers. Aside from the four Intel Extreme Masters events that we work on with ESL, we also work on six ESL One events and we also have ESL Pro League investments, Overwatch investments and even the Grand Slam investments. A couple months ago, we had announced that we'd entered into a new three-year agreement with ESL where we're going to be spending 100 million dollars between 2019-2021. We're just fortunate to be in the position to have started this with ESL, some 15 years ago, to now see what it has turned into. What I really love is when IEM or ESL One comes to a new place where it hasn't been before. We've seen several times that it can help accelerate the move into gaming and the growth of esports. Intel Extreme Masters doesn't move around much but ESL One does, so it's a great way to bring esports to the masses. I hope that the audience and the fans here in Mumbai see as much value and get as much enjoyment as we have seen happen in many other places.

What made you decide upon Mumbai as the destination for ESL One?

Frank Soqui: I think it was the potential for growth. A lot of things sort of

feed the potential for growth including the population, the infrastructure, the demographics, and the interest in gaming. A lot of such factors were starting to come together. Although, in general it looks small-ish, we're looking at potential for rapid growth. And we think that over the last 18-24 months, that has been evolving pretty quickly here in India. So instead of waiting till it's too late, we wanted to be at the front of where the growth is going to happen which is why we're here in Mumbai.

If you look at the local scene, then CS:GO is more happening than Dota 2. So why not have a CS:GO tournament rather than a Dota 2 tournament?

Frank Soqui: We could have had an IEM here but we just intercepted ESL One, this is the way for us to first go experience and test the market with them. So we're sponsoring this, we have a lot of money and skin in the game. We started with Dota 2 because sometimes it comes down to the opportunity that the ISV also sees. So we have to listen to what everyone has to say and we figure out who's interested and who wants to partner with us before going ahead. 